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December 6, 1943

In reply refer to
EH

My dear Mr. Secretary:

I refer to your letter of November 24, 1943 expressing concern over the delay which has occurred in bringing into effect plans developed by the World Jewish Congress for the evacuation of a large number of Jews from Rumania and France. In view of certain implications contained in your letter, particularly those referring to Minister Harrison, I have had the entire matter reviewed.

(1) The two proposals referred to in your letter have, as I understand it, never been fully developed in all of their fundamental details. The feasibility of the Rumanian proposal on the basis on which the Treasury has indicated its approval, was submitted early in August to Dr. Riegner, the representative in Switzerland of the World Jewish Congress. On August 22, the Legation at Bern reported that Dr. Riegner was not prepared to express an opinion on the feasibility of the plan until he had consulted with the Rumanian Jewish organization. As far as the Department is aware, no further word has ever been received from Dr. Riegner in this connection.

(2) In the case of the French plan, Dr. Riegner expressed the opinion that the attempt would be worthwhile. However, the plan for the establishment of blocked accounts referred to in your letter was, as the Department understands it, abandoned in favor of the purchase of French currency in Switzerland, which the Treasury was prepared to approve on condition that the American Legation at Bern or some other responsible agency approve each purchase to insure certain conditions as to the origin of the currency. The Legation has made clear that these conditions are impossible of fulfillment. In this connection, Censorship reports, which are assumed to be available to Treasury, indicate that the Swiss market in French currency

The Honorable

Henry Morgenthau, Jr.,

Secretary of the Treasury.